

Became a WER

■ By Sharda Ugra in Beijing

New Delhi, 2028. It is the Olympic 100 m men's final. The fastest men in the world are coiled in their blocks, waiting for the gunshot that will start off the 10 most important seconds of their lives. India is an eager Olympic host but not represented in the race. There is momentary silence in the heaving stadium, interrupted by the crack of the starter's pistol. The race has begun, the sprinters' giant side-stepping strides consuming the hundred metres before them.

With metres to go, past runners from the United States, Britain, the Caribbean islands and Africa, comes a blood-red blur from an outside lane. In a supernova of flashbulbs, it goes over the line before all others; for the first time in history, a Chinese athlete is Olympic 100-m champion.

Don't snigger. It can happen. If the world's most committed and organised sporting nation puts its mind to producing an Olympic sprint champion in two decades, never mind can, it *will* happen. The Beijing Olympics is proof that what

Photographs by REUTERS and Photomontage by SAURABH SINGH



Guo Jingjing: With six Olympic diving medals in her kitty, she is considered the most successful woman diver in Olympics history

